

ENEMIES OF ROME

The expansion of Rome's influence from a small settlement in central Italy to an imperial power that ruled a huge empire brought its armies face to face with a wide range of foes. Although the individual equipment of most enemy warriors may have been superb, their training and organization was almost always inferior to that of the Roman army. However, the Roman infantry did struggle against the mounted warriors of Persia and the Hunnish archers, and by the time the Franks, the Ostrogoths, and other Germanic groups poured into the empire from the 4th century CE onwards, the Roman army was too weakened to resist them.

▼ BRONZE SAMNITE BREASTPLATE

Date 4th century BCE

Origin Central Italy

Material Bronze

Made of three convex bronze discs, this breastplate would have been matched by a similar piece to protect the back. Such armour was worn by Rome's opponents, the Samnite tribes, in three wars in central Italy from 343–290 BCE.

Bronze wings

Rivet holes for fastening armour

Red glass enamel studs

Convex bronze disc

Decorative bronze metalwork on hilt

◀ BATTERSEA SHIELD

Date 350–50 BCE

Origin England

Weight 3.4kg (7½lb)

Diameter 35.7cm (14in)

This ornate decorative bronze cover to a wooden shield, found in the River Thames at Battersea, London, was probably for parade use. It is made of four sheets of bronze riveted together.

▲ CELTIC DAGGER

Date 250–50 BCE

Origin England

Length 27.8cm (11in)

The intricate spiral-pattern decoration on this Celtic dagger indicates that it was probably intended for funerary or display purposes, rather than combat. Its sharply tapering blade was typical of everyday weapons.

Silver-covered scabbard